

Class 10th | English



First Flight

The Ball Poem

LECTURE - 2

QUESTIONS

1. Why does the poet say, "I would not intrude on him"?
Why doesn't he offer him money to buy another ball?

Ans. The poet says, "I would not intrude on him" because he does not want to interfere in the natural process of learning. He wants the boy to learn the meaning of loss on his own. He also doesn't offer him money to buy another ball because that would be worthless. He wants the boy to learn the lesson of responsibility and accept that losses are a part of life.

QUESTIONS

2. '.... staring down

All his young days into the harbour where His ball went'

Do you think the boy has had the ball for a long time? Is it linked to the memories of days when he played with it?

Ans. Yes, the boy has had the ball for a long time. It is linked to the memories of days when the boy played with it.

When it bounced into the water, all his memories of the days of his childhood flashed in front of him. This led to a realisation that those moments would not come back, just like the ball. He can buy new balls and can similarly create new moments, but those memories which are gone would not return.

QUESTIONS

3. What does 'in the world of possessions' mean?

Ans. The phrase 'in the world of possessions' means that we are living in a world where everybody is worried about material possessions. Today's world encourages materialism and a sense of possession. Every one is in the race of possessing more and more.

QUESTIONS

4. Do you think the boy has lost anything earlier? Pick out the words that suggest the answer.

Ans. No, it seems that the boy had not lost anything earlier.
The words that suggest so are 'He senses first responsibility in a world of possessions'

QUESTIONS

5. What does the poet say the boy is learning from the loss of the ball? Try to explain this in your own words.

Ans. The poet says that the boy is learning to bear the loss of the ball. He is experiencing grief and learning to grow up in this world of possessions. He learns that there are so many things in life that are lost and cannot be brought back. He is sensing his first responsibility as he has lost the ball. The boy will learn how to stand up and leave the losses behind as he would have understood the true meaning and nature of loss.

QUESTIONS

6. Identify the literary device used in 'And no one buys a ball back.'

- (a) Metaphor
- (b) Simile
- (c) Alliteration ✓
- (d) Anaphora

QUESTIONS

Ans. (c) Alliteration

QUESTIONS

7. What is the tone of The Ball Poem towards the end?

- (a) Encouraging ✓
- (b) Depressing
- (c) Happy
- (d) Exciting

QUESTIONS

Ans. (a) Encouraging

QUESTIONS

8. "No use to say 'O there are other balls"

Which of these is the poet conveying in the above line from 'The Ball Poem'?

- (a) There are multiple choices in life. ✗
- (b) What is lost is often irreplaceable. ✓✓
- (c) Collecting things is a sign of greed. ✓
- (d) Grown ups can cope with loss easily. ✓

QUESTIONS

Ans. (b) What is lost is often irreplaceable.

QUESTIONS

9. Which of these best describes the poet's tone in 'The Ball Poem'?
- (a) It is rational as he analyses the incident like an experienced adult. ✓
 - (b) It is regretful as he is not able to console the boy even though he wants to. ✓
 - (c) It is indifferent as he says that one must not console the boy who is crying. ✓
 - (d) It is full of wonder as he observes the boy closely to discover the nature of loss. ✓

QUESTIONS

Ans. (d) It is full of wonder as he observes the boy closely to discover the nature of loss.

QUESTIONS

10. Select the option that shows the correct relationship between (1) and (2) from 'The Ball Poem'.

1. The poet chooses not to intrude on the boy.

2. The poet believes loss to be permanent and irreparable.

- (a) 2 is the meaning of 1
- (b) 2 is the opposite of 1
- (c) 2 explains the reason for 1
- (d) 2 is a fact and 1 is an opinion

QUESTIONS

Ans. (d) 2 is a fact and 1 is an opinion

QUESTIONS

11. Read the following extracts carefully and answer the questions that follow.

What is the boy now, who has lost his ball,
What, what is he to do? I saw it go
Merrily bouncing, down the street, and then Merrily
over- there it is in the water!

H/10

QUESTIONS

- i. Mention the situation that corresponds to the emotion behind the exclamation mark in the poem.

Ans. I don't know where I've placed my ID-card. Let me check the bag once more, Ah, finally!

QUESTIONS

- ii. The poem begins with a question. Based on your reading of the poem, state what the speaker is doing?

Ans. Based on the poem, it can be said that the poet is thinking to himself.

QUESTIONS

- iii. The extract suggests that the poet is _____.
- (a) an onlooker observing
 - (b) a parent recounting the incident.
 - (c) the boy talking about himself
 - (d) imagining the incident

QUESTIONS

Ans. (a) an onlooker observing

QUESTIONS

iv. What does the poet seem to have indicated the 'Merry bouncing of the ball' to?

Ans. The poet seems to have indicated the 'Merry bouncing of the ball' to contrast with the dejected feeling of the boy.

QUESTIONS

12. Read the following extract carefully and answer the questions that follow.

Merrily over — there it is in the water!
 No use to say 'O there are other balls':
 An ultimate shaking grief fixes the boy
 As he stands rigid, trembling, staring down
 All his young days into the harbour where
 His ball went. I would not intrude on him;
 A dime, another ball, is worthless.

..... Now

He senses first responsibility
 In a world of possessions. People will take
 Balls, balls will be lost always, little boy.
 And no one buys a ball back.
 Money is external.

H/W

QUESTIONS

- i. Complete the conversation with what the boy would most likely say. Answer in about 40 words.

"John Oh don't worry, there are plenty of other balls to play with".

Boy _____.

Ans. No, there is none like that ball as that ball was special to me.

QUESTIONS

- ii.** Which line first indicates that the ball is a metaphor for something else?
- (a)** Merrily over - there it is in the water!
 - (b)** An ultimate shaking grief fixes the boy
 - (c)** All his young days into the harbour where
 - (d)** I would not intrude on him

QUESTIONS

Ans. (c) All his young days into the harbour where

QUESTIONS

iii. Which literary device does the speaker use to describe the boy's sorrow? Why does the speaker use this device? Answer in about 40 words.

Ans. The speaker uses visual imagery to describe the boy's sorrow because it creates a clear picture of the depth of the boy's grief. The lines 'An ultimate shaking grief fixes the boy /As he stands rigid, trembling, staring down' paints a visual picture of the boy's grief and sorrow.

QUESTIONS

iv. Based on the extract, what makes a possession valuable? Answer in about 40 words.

Ans. The line 'And no one buys a ball back. Money is external' indicates that the value of a possession is not determined by its cost or monetary value. Instead, the value of a possession is determined by the emotional attachment towards it, as seen in the way the boy values his ball.

QUESTIONS

13. What does John Berryman want to convey through this poem?

Or Write the sum and substance of the poem 'The Ball Poem'.

Or Explain briefly the central idea of the poem.

Ans. The poet, John Berryman through the poem, wants to convey the importance of loss and responsibility in life.

We all should learn our responsibility and how to cope up with the loss.

The poet also wants us to learn that things will get lost from time to time and money simply cannot replace them all.

QUESTIONS

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14. What is the boy's loss of his ball used as a metaphor for? Support your answer with one point of evidence.

Ans. Yes, the lost ball stands as a metaphor of the boy's lost childhood. The boy has lost his ball and is saddened by the loss as it will never be found again. This loss will lead to the loss of childhood innocence as the boy learns to take responsibility.

The boy now understands that loss is a part of life and one must move on from it. This realisation makes the boy grow up and lose the childhood days that he cherished till now.

QUESTIONS

15. "Money is external." What does the poet mean by this expression?

Or Why does the poet say 'Money is external in the poem'?

Ans. The poet says that 'Money is external' to make the boy understand about his responsibility and that the loss is immaterial. By this phrase, the poet means that every loss cannot be replaced by money. Money cannot buy the memories associated with a thing and cannot replace the things that we love, for example the boy's lost ball.

QUESTIONS

16. Why was the boy upset on losing his ball?

Ans. The boy was upset on losing his ball because it was his valued possession. It was a much loved possession which he had since his childhood. It had been with him for a long time and was linked to the memories of the days when he played with it. Now, the ball was lost forever for him. He could buy a new ball but the memories with the lost ball is lost forever.

QUESTIONS

17. A popular quote states: 'Responsibility is self-taught. How does the poem address this thought? 

Ans. The quote 'Responsibility is self-taught' is central to the poem. The poet addresses this thought by becoming an observer to the situation of the boy. He could have gone to the boy and bought him a new ball. However, he wanted the boy to learn for himself that his irresponsibility cost him the ball. Until and unless, he comes to the realisation on his own, he would not learn anything about responsibility.

QUESTIONS

18. Recount your reaction to the loss of a favourite object as a very young child. Would you have behaved the same way now? Explain with reason.

Ans. Yes, I would have reacted in a similar manner as the boy. However, if I lose something now, I do not act in the similar manner because I have realised that losses are a part of our lives and we need to move on from them.



QUESTIONS

19. What does the poet mean by epistemology of loss in 'The Ball Poem'?

Ans. The given phrase, 'epistemology of loss' means understanding the meaning and nature of loss.

According to the poet, the epistemology of loss is the greatest lesson, the boy is learning. It teaches him to value and preserve his cherished things.

It also teaches him to recover from the loss and move on with his life.

When we try to understand what it means to lose something, we are more careful about the further losses. Thus, it helps us to be self-reliant and stand up on our own feet.

QUESTIONS

20. He senses first responsibility in a world of possessions.

In the above lines from 'The Ball Poem' what does the poet mean when he says that the boy senses 'first responsibility' after losing the ball? Answer in 20-30 words.

Ans. The given line and phrase indicate that this is the first time the boy has lost something. As a result, he understands the meaning and nature of loss. This first loss teaches him to value and preserve his cherished things. It also teaches him to recover from the loss and move on with his life. When we try to understand what it means to lose something, we are more careful to check the further losses. Thus, it helps us to be self-reliant and stand up on our own feet.

QUESTIONS

21. Why is it important for everyone to experience loss and to stand up after it?

Ans. Experiencing loss is a fundamental aspect of the human condition. It teaches resilience (courage), empathy and the profound strength found in hardships. It allows one to appreciate the changing nature of life and encourages personal growth. Standing up after loss is crucial as it signifies not only the physical strength to carry on but it is also a proof of the undefeatable human spirit. It signifies the transformative power of adversity, molding grief into strength. This journey of recovery encourages a deeper understanding of oneself, while also making the person emotionally strong.

QUESTIONS

Through the loss of ball, the boy learns real knowledge of the world. If he is able to bear the loss, he will be able to face the difficulties of life courageously. The boy must know how to stand up after a loss. It is very essential for every human being to be able to move on or stand up after being knocked down. Here, the ball signifies losing something valuable that can not be bought or replaced. The poet wants us to understand that loss is inevitable and everyone must learn to cope up with the loss with patience and courage.

QUESTIONS

22. The poem deals with a child understanding loss for the first time. Matches and championships too, deal with a different sense of loss. Explain how games and sports are a good way to train children to take losses in their stride.

Ans. Matches and championships related to games and sports teach children many things. From team building skills to personality development, sports and games are important for the many life lesson it gives to children. One of the most important of these skills is to have true sportsman spirit which enables the child to take all of his/her failures in stride.

Sports teaches a child that winning and losing is not central to the game, it is enjoying the spirit of the game. Even if one loses a match, one does not leave a sport for the lack of confidence. One learns from this loss and practices to better oneself. It teaches children to move on from the losses.

QUESTIONS

23. "Not from weeping nor from grieving will anyone obtain peace of mind".

If you had to use the message of the given quote from the Buddha's sermon (The Sermon at Benares) to help the boy cope with the loss of his ball and what it signifies (The Ball Poem), what would you include in your advice?

Ans. The Buddha's words teach us to cope with the loss of irreplaceable things. They tell us that the loss of irreparable things brings griefs and sorrow but as wise people we must learn to stay calm and accept the loss while understanding that we might lose things we love, even people we once loved. The existence of some things in our lives is ephemeral.

This acceptance helps us in living normally and forgetting about loss.

These words can help the boy in 'The Ball Poem' cope with the loss of the ball by making him understand that loss is a constant and important part of life. Only by learning to accept and adapt to it can we live a normal life.

QUESTIONS

This notion might be too difficult for the boy to understand because he is too young. He is all alone in his loss. There is no one beside him to explain everything about the loss. So, he must learn from his experience painstakingly. For the same he may require time to cope since he can easily feel disheartened at such a young age.

QUESTIONS

H/W

- 24.** You have been chosen to address the school assembly, to speak on the epistemology of loss and the epistemology of loss and the resilience of the human spirit during times of crisis. Prepare the speech draft, with reference to the commonality of themes in 'The Ball Poem' by John Berryman and 'From the Diary of Anne Frank'.

You may begin this way

Good morning everyone, Today, I'd like to discuss two pieces of literature that offer a powerful insight into how to deal with loss and the resilience of the human spirit required during times of crisis.

You may end this way

To conclude, I'd like to say that Thank you.

QUESTIONS

Ans. Good morning everyone Today, I'd like to discuss two pieces of literature that offer a powerful insight into how to deal with loss and the resilience of human spirit required during the time of crisis.

The first piece is the poem "The Ball Poem" by John Berryman. The poem essentially covers the universality of loss and the need to move on from the loss. The poem, essentially, shows how each one of us need to learn the nature of loss so that we can accept it as truth and learn to live with it without grieving over it all our life.

The second piece of literature is 'From the Diary of Anne Frank' wherein Anne talks about loss of her grandmother and a peaceful life during the Nazi Holocaust. Anne lost her grandmother at a young age but that did not stop her from moving her with her life.

QUESTIONS

She remembered her grandmother every year but did not spend her time in grief. Even when faced with difficult times during the holocaust, Anne does not give up. She writes her diary with the hope for better days.

Thus, with courage and determination, we need to learn to move on from loss and grief.to deal with loss and the resilience of human spirit required during the time of crisis.

The first piece is the poem

"The Ball Poem' by John Berryman. The poem essentially covers the universality of loss and the need to move on from the loss. The poem, essentially, shows how each one of us need to learn the nature of loss so that we can accept it as truth and learn to live with it without grieving over it all our life.

QUESTIONS

The second piece of literature is 'From the Diary of Anne Frank' wherein Anne talks about loss of her grandmother and a peaceful life during the Nazi Holocaust. Anne lost her grandmother at a young age but that did not stop her from moving her with her life. She remembered her grandmother every year but did not spend her time in grief. Even when faced with difficult times during the holocaust, Anne does not give up. She writes her diary with the hope for better days.

Thus, with courage and determination, we need to learn to move on from loss and grief.

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